Seranai

OpenFOS

Open Founder Operating System

Customer Discovery & Interview Design

24 Skills + 2 Reference Modules
Organized by FOUNDRY Framework

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What Is This Skill?

The Customer Discovery Interview skill is an AI-powered simulation tool that helps founders find out whether their customer's problem is real — before writing a single line of code, hiring a designer, or spending money on a landing page.

It works as a guided conversation. You describe your startup idea and who you think your customer is. The skill does two things no other tool can: it builds a custom set of discovery interview questions tailored to your specific idea, and then simulates a real customer answering those questions — honestly, not politely.

At the end of the session you receive a scored analysis of whether the problem is real, how urgent it is, and exactly what to do next.

> **THE CORE PRINCIPLE**
>
> Most founders collect polite agreement and call it validation.
> This skill is built to break that habit.
> Simulated customer answers are realistic, not flattering. The goal is evidence — not encouragement.

By the end of one session (about 20 minutes), you will have a complete set of discovery questions, a realistic simulation of how a real customer would respond, a scored signal analysis across five dimensions, and a concrete action plan for your first real interviews.

Who Is This For?

This skill is designed for founders who have an idea but have not yet talked to customers — or who want to sharpen their approach before real conversations. It is especially useful if:

- You have an idea and want to know if the problem is actually painful enough before building
- You have never done customer discovery before and want a safe place to practise
- You have done some interviews but keep hearing 'that sounds cool' and want to know if it means anything
- You want a ready-to-use interview script before your next customer conversation
- You are not sure whether you are targeting the right customer and want to test two personas side by side
- You are in an early market where finding real customers to talk to is difficult

This skill works for founders anywhere in the world. Whether you are in Lagos, Bangalore, Dubai, São Paulo, or San Francisco, the methodology adapts to your market and the type of customer you are building for.

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How to Get Started

Using this skill requires three things: access to Claude (claude.ai or the Claude app), the Customer Discovery Interview skill installed, and your idea described in your own words.

Step 1: Open Claude and Start a New Conversation

Go to claude.ai or open the Claude app. Start a new conversation. That is it.

Step 2: Describe Your Idea

Tell Claude what problem you think exists, who you think has it, and what you are considering building. You do not need a polished pitch. A single sentence is enough to start — the skill will ask follow-up questions for anything it still needs.

Examples of Great Starting Messages

EXAMPLE 1 — Detailed

"I'm building a task management app for remote construction site managers. The problem is they can't track daily progress across multiple sub-contractors without calling everyone. I think the customer is a site manager at a 50-person contractor firm."

EXAMPLE 2 — Brief

"Invoicing tool for freelance designers in India. I think they waste 3–4 hours a week on admin."

EXAMPLE 3 — Minimal

"Something to help small restaurant owners manage their staff rotas."

All three of these work. The more specific you are about the customer, the sharper the simulation will be. But even a rough description is enough — the skill will extract what it needs from whatever you provide.

Step 3: Follow the Conversation

The skill guides you through five phases. You do not need to prepare anything in advance. Just describe your idea and respond naturally to what the skill asks. The whole process takes about 20 minutes.

What Happens: The Five Phases

The skill walks you through five phases, each building on the last. Here is what to expect at each stage.

PHASE 1: UNDERSTAND YOUR IDEA
Your customer and problem locked in • ~2 minutes

	What You Do	What You Get
	• Describe your product idea in one or two sentences	• Your idea restated clearly as a customer problem statement

	• Name who you think the customer is and what problem they have	• Confirmation of what the skill already knows vs. what it still needs • A fast-path check: if your idea is clear, the skill moves straight to building questions

WHY THIS MATTERS:

The skill never asks you to fill in a form or repeat yourself.

If your customer type, location, or problem appears anywhere in the conversation, it carries that forward.

This keeps the process fast and focused on what matters.

PHASE 2: BUILD THE INTERVIEW QUESTION SET

Your custom discovery questions ready to use • ~3 minutes

	What You Do	What You Get
	• Review the 10–12 questions the skill builds for your specific idea • Ask to add, remove, or adjust any question before the simulation begins	• A tailored set of discovery questions across five categories: customer context, problem discovery, current solutions, pain intensity, and buying signal • A Mom Test coaching note explaining why none of the questions mention your solution • A ready-to-print interview script you can use in real conversations

PHASE 3: THE SIMULATED INTERVIEW

A realistic customer answers every question • ~8 minutes

	What You Do	What You Get
	• Read through each question and the simulated customer's answer • Ask the skill to probe deeper on any answer that surprises you • Stop the simulation at any point to ask a coaching question	• A named, profiled simulated customer who responds realistically — not too positively, not too negatively • A coach note after every answer flagging the signal strength: weak, moderate, strong, or hair on fire

		• Honest pushback when an answer reveals a polite non-answer rather than real pain

PHASE 4: SIGNAL ANALYSIS
Scored assessment of what the answers actually mean • ~4 minutes

	What You Do	What You Get
	• Review the scored breakdown across all five question categories • Read the Key Findings: what is real, what is uncertain, and what are red flags • Review any questions you wrote that violated Mom Test principles — with corrected versions	• A Signal Scorecard scored out of 25 with a plain-English interpretation • A clear verdict: strong signal, mixed signal, weak signal, or no signal — with specific reasons • A list of interview mistakes to avoid in real conversations, with corrected versions of any leading or hypothetical questions

PHASE 5: WHAT TO DO NEXT
A concrete action plan for real interviews • ~3 minutes to read

	What You Do	What You Get
	• Review where to find real people to interview based on your customer profile • Confirm how many interviews to run based on your signal score • Review what to listen for — and what to ignore — in real conversations	• Three specific places to find real customers to interview today • A recommended interview count based on your signal strength • Three phrases that mean 'this is real pain' and three that mean 'this is polite agreement' • A final verdict on your overall Discovery Score out of 25

Understanding Your Results

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The Five Question Categories — and Why They Matter

Every discovery interview question in this skill falls into one of five categories. Together, they cover the full picture of whether a problem is real and worth solving.

Category	What It Reveals
Customer Context	Establishes how the customer spends their time and what they prioritise. Without this, every answer about pain is missing context.
Problem Discovery	Surfaces the real frustrations the customer experiences — without mentioning your solution. This is where most founders find out the problem is not what they assumed.
Current Solutions	Reveals what the customer already does. If they have a workaround, the problem is real. If they have no workaround, urgency is unclear.
Pain Intensity	Measures how urgently the customer wants this solved. The difference between 'nice to have' and 'I need this fixed now' shows up here.
Buying Signal	Tests past behaviour around spending — not hypothetical intent. Has the customer searched for solutions? Paid for anything? This is the strongest predictor of whether they would pay you.

Reading the Signal Strength

After every simulated answer, the skill gives a signal rating. Here is what each rating means and how to use it.

Signal	What It Looks Like	What It Means
🔴 **Weak**	*Customer is polite but hasn't tried to solve it before*	No budget or time spent on this — may be a vitamin
🟡 **Moderate**	*Customer acknowledges pain but has lived with it for months*	Problem exists but urgency is unclear — dig deeper
🟢 **Strong**	*Customer has paid money or significant time trying to solve this*	Real pain with evidence of spend — strong signal
💎 **Hair on Fire**	*Customer says 'if you can fix this, I'd switch tomorrow'*	Urgent, active pain — the highest signal you can get

Reading Your Discovery Score

At the end of the simulation, the skill produces an overall Discovery Score out of 25. Here is how to interpret it.

Score	Rating	What to Do Next
20 – 25	**Strong signal**	The problem is real, painful, and urgent. Ready for real interviews.

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13 – 19	**Mixed signal**	Pain exists but urgency is unclear. Run 15–20 real interviews to find patterns.
7 – 12	**Weak signal**	Problem acknowledged but not actively being solved. Reconsider the framing.
Below 7	**No signal**	May be a vitamin, not a painkiller. Consider pivoting the problem.

Tips for Getting the Most Out of This Skill

Be specific about your customer. The more precisely you describe who you are building for, the more realistic the simulation. 'Small business owners' is too broad. 'Operations managers at logistics companies with 10–50 employees' gives the skill enough to simulate a real person.

Do not pitch during the simulation. The skill will break character and stop you if you reveal your solution. This is intentional. Real customers do not know your product exists — and the simulation is most valuable when you honour that.

'I don't know' moves you forward. If you are unsure how to describe your customer, just say so. The skill will ask the one question most likely to unblock you. Uncertainty is data — it tells you what to clarify before talking to real people.

Run it for two different customers. If you are deciding between two target segments, run the full simulation for each. The contrast in signal scores is often more revealing than either score alone.

Use the script in real interviews. The questions generated in Phase 2 are not just for the simulation. They follow Mom Test principles and are ready to use with real customers the same day.

Come back after real interviews. Once you have spoken to real customers, paste your notes into a new session. The skill will analyse them using the same Signal Scorecard and tell you whether your real data confirms or contradicts the simulation.

Frequently Asked Questions

Do I need to have done the earlier skills first?

Not strictly. But the more you know about your target customer and problem going in, the sharper the simulation will be. If you have completed Problem Validation (Skill 1) and Persona Definition (Skill 4), your customer description will be precise enough to make the simulated answers genuinely useful.

How realistic is the simulated customer?

The simulation is built on common behavioral patterns for the customer type you describe — typical frustrations, typical workarounds, typical levels of urgency. It will not match any specific real person, but it is specifically designed to not be flattering. If the simulated customer sounds enthusiastic, it is because the problem is genuinely painful for that profile — not because the skill is being polite.

What if I already have interview notes from real conversations?

Paste them in. If you bring real interview notes to the session, the skill will skip the simulation entirely and go straight to Signal Analysis using your real data. Real interview notes produce more accurate scores than a simulation — use them whenever you have them.

Can I change the questions before the simulation runs?

Yes. After Phase 2 generates your question set, you can ask to add, remove, or rephrase any question before the simulation begins. You can also ask the skill to explain why a specific question was included or excluded.

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What if I get a low Discovery Score?

A low score is valuable information, not a failure. It tells you the problem may be a vitamin rather than a painkiller, or that you are targeting the wrong customer, or that the urgency is not there yet. The skill will explain which dimension is weakest and what would need to be true for the score to improve. That is exactly the kind of clarity most founders pay accelerators for.

Can I simulate multiple customer types in the same session?

Yes. Ask the skill to run a second simulation with a different customer profile. After both simulations, the skill will compare the signal scores side by side and recommend which segment shows stronger, more urgent pain. This is one of the most useful things you can do before deciding who to target first.

How long does it take?

About 20 minutes for the full five-phase session. Faster if your customer description is specific. Longer if you want to simulate two customer types or spend time on the coaching notes in Phase 3.

Is my data private?

Your conversation is between you and Claude. The skill does not store or share your business details with anyone.

The FOUNDRY Framework

FOUNDRY is the sequential journey framework that guides founders from initial idea through scale or exit. Each letter represents a stage, and each stage contains specific skills a founder needs to master.

Stage	Purpose	Skills
F – Foundation	Validate the idea. Confirm the problem is real, the market exists, and you know who to serve.	Skills 1–4
O – Outline	Design the business. Articulate value, map competition, model revenue, scope the MVP.	Skills 5–8
U – User	Acquire and understand customers. Discover needs, design GTM, set pricing, run experiments.	Skills 9–12
N – Nurture	Build relationships and traction. Craft the pitch, model financials, build the founder narrative.	Skills 13–15
D – Discipline	Execute and operate. Set OKRs, hire the team, handle legal and entity setup.	Skills 16–18
R – Results	Measure and iterate. Track KPIs, assess PMF, decide whether to pivot or persevere.	Skills 19–20
Y – Yield	Scale or exit. Confirm scaling readiness, plan liquidity events.	Skills 21–22

Cross-cutting skills (23–24) are not stage-specific and can be invoked at any point in the journey.

Reference modules (R1–R2) are shared evaluation lenses that multiple skills invoke. They are never used in isolation.

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